

What is helping?

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(This is a short essay that won [third place](#) in the Brazilian Annual Philosophy Contest. A longer version is in progress.)

Introduction

This essay does not aim to define "helping," but rather to determine where it falls within the taxonomy of moral actions. Socrates would probably agree that, although conceptual definitions are important, knowing "what is x" is meant to guide us in living a good life. Fitting helping into the taxonomy of moral actions certainly has a significant impact on this guidance. After all, knowing what type of action each instance of helping belongs to automatically provides the normativity for when we should engage in helping behavior.

The neat taxonomy of moral actions comprises the following (Chisholm 1963):

- (i) Obligations: actions that are good to do and bad not to do.
- (ii) Indifferent: actions that are neither good to do nor bad not to do.
- (iii) Prohibitions: actions that are bad to do and good not to do.

As far as armchair philosophy goes, these categories should be exhaustive (Urmson 1958). Common sense, however, challenges their sufficiency. For one thing, people behave as if there were imperfect obligations. These are usually considered a subset of (i), encompassing actions that

(iv) are good to do and bad not to do, with the added imperfectness qualification making it permissible to not do them sometimes.

The qualification was added for practical reasons. There are certain obligations that would be too demanding to comply with all the time. Altruism is the most common example; after all, helping at every opportunity can be overwhelming (Schroeder 2013).

A second missing category consists of supererogatory actions, which
(v) are good to do, but not bad not to do.

Since supererogatory actions are not bad not to do, they are completely optional. As such, they will never be too demanding. Altruism is the most common example. While no one denies that helping is good, we often act as if it is mostly up to each individual. Therefore, not helping is not bad.

Most philosophical discussions of supererogation or imperfect duties contrast them with the concept of a perfect obligation (Rainbolt 2000, Ignieski 2001, but see Portmore 2023). However, since they share the paradigmatic example of altruism, the most pressing practical problem becomes determining whether an instance of helping is supererogatory or an imperfect duty. After all, this distinction leads to different compliance norms, since supererogation is optional, but imperfect obligations are not.

Finally, an even smaller number of philosophers advocate including yet another type of action in the taxonomy. Considerate actions (Ullmann-Margalit 2011, Calhoun 2004)
(vi) are good to do, not bad not to do, and they come at almost no cost to the agent.

Paradigmatic examples include small acts of kindness, such as helping someone cross the street. Yet again, many instances of helping fall under the category of considerateness.

In short, considering common sense and ordinary behavior adds three categories to the taxonomy of moral actions that are deeply intertwined with helping behavior. This intertwining raises the question: Is helping an imperfect obligation, a supererogation, or a considerate action?

Determining the proper place for different instances of helping is important for more than just theoretical refinement. Classifying help into one category or another will yield different compliance requirements. Since this moral behavior is fundamental to any functioning society, categorizing helping behaviors and their intersections will provide essential guidance for our behavior in the world.

Method

Every question comes with a second question that must be answered first. One must always choose — consciously or not — the method to arrive at a proper answer. Philosophers examining supererogation, imperfect duties, and considerateness always rely on common sense to justify the importance of their work (Dreier 2004, MacNamara 2011, Portmore 2023). Even though most philosophical debates tend to neglect these categories, we must understand them because they are part of the morality in the wild. Despite this pervasive and compelling justification, there have been no empirical attempts to consult common sense in a statistically valid way to address these categories (see Horgan and Timmons 2023 and Archer 2023 for complaints). The aim of this essay is to begin addressing this deficit.

The first step in this type of empirical investigation is to operationalize the relevant concepts. This means defining abstract concepts as measurable, observable variables so they can be tested. For this purpose, I will rely on two dimensions: cost and frequency. After all, having almost no cost to the agent is part of the definition of considerateness. Conversely, the potentially high cost of certain obligations paves the way for accepting imperfect obligations (and supererogation). Since morality is a multiple iterative game, costs also depend on frequency. A frequency spectrum ranges from ‘never’ going through ‘sometimes’ all the way up to ‘always’. These frequencies are relevant to the present investigation since an imperfect obligation must be complied with at least sometimes, while supererogation is fully optional and, as such, can never be performed. Thus, the following scheme will be used to determine where helping falls within the three categories:

Considerate: A good action that does not cost the agent anything.

Supererogation: A good action that can always or never be done.

Imperfect obligation: A good action that would be too costly to perform always, but that must be performed sometimes.

This operationalization scheme guided the creation of seven conditions to test when and if common sense treats helping as considerateness, an imperfect duty, or supererogation. Additionally, two conditions were created to determine if suberogation and imperfect permissions exist (more on that in the bonus section at the end).

Empirical tests

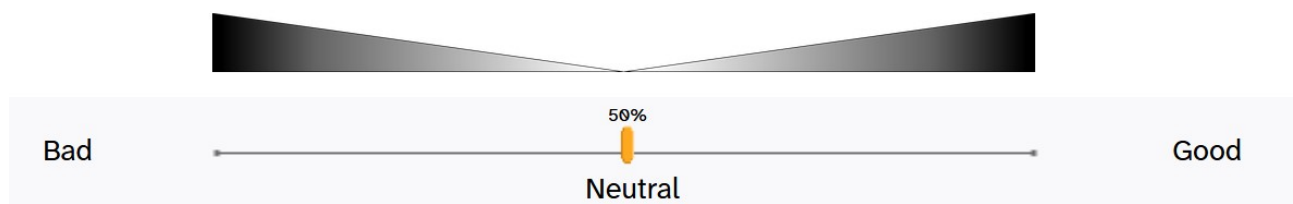
In a pre-registered study (<https://osf.io/btxp5/>), 120 participants (59 female and 61 male; mean age: 38 years old) were recruited via Prolific to read different scenarios describing helping behaviors. After each scenario, they used a VAS (Visual Analogue Scale) from 0 to 100 to indicate the extent to which they thought the presented behavior was bad, neutral, or good. The visual scale accommodates the nuance required to judge moral cases.

Analysis 1: Never

The Never Help condition provides an idea of what the scenarios are like (all scenarios are available at the link above).

John NEVER helps anyone. To be clear, he never breaks the law or harms anyone. However, no matter how small the task, he is never willing to help others. When his friends need help, he's never there. When he bumps into strangers who need a little help, he always ignores them. Even when he has the opportunity to provide life-changing help to others, he dismisses it, no matter how small the cost to him. In short, John NEVER helps those in need—not even once.

How moral do you think John's behavior is?



The descriptive statistics reveal a mean sample score of 25.3, with a standard deviation of 19.01. It is important to keep in mind that 0 marks the negative extreme, "Bad" going through 50, which is perfectly "Neutral", until reaching 100, the positive extreme, "Good." A one-sample t-test was also conducted to determine whether the evaluation differed significantly from the neutral midpoint of 50. The results confirm that participants judged the behavior to be blameworthy: $t(60) = -10.56$, $p < 0.001$, and $d = -1.35$. A p-value less than 0.001 means that if this result were just a statistical fluke, the odds of us observing data this compelling are less than 0.1%. A Cohen's d of -1.35 is also substantial since 0.8 is considered a large effect in psychology. Thus, people clearly think that never helping is bad. If never helping is bad, then helping is not optional; we cannot choose to never help. Therefore, helping cannot be supererogatory.

Given such a strong result, it is likely that the reader agrees with the blameworthiness of the helper and may even think that the judgment is too obvious to be worthy of empirical investigation. However, this analysis's novelty lies less in the expected result and more in approaching the matter from the "never" perspective. In contrast, philosophical discussions tend to start with the "always" side of the frequency spectrum, deny it, and then derive a "never" to conclude that helping is supererogatory. The reasoning goes as follows:

By definition, if x is a moral obligation, then x must always be fulfilled. Thus, if helping is an obligation, then we must always help. However, always helping is clearly too demanding. Since it is reasonable to assume that people should be able to fulfill their moral obligations, they cannot be too demanding. Therefore, helping cannot be an obligation. Moreover, if an action is not an obligation, doing it is optional, so much so that it is permissible to never do it. Therefore, it is permissible never to help. Lastly, since helping is undeniably good but optional, then helping is supererogatory.

Of course, the reconstructed reasoning is only valid if there is no such thing as an imperfect obligation, which only claims that we must help sometimes, thereby opening the way to avoid

excessive demand.¹ And, in fact, many philosophers think that an imperfect obligation is either an inconsistent notion, since obligations must be obligatory, or an indeterminate notion, since it leaves open when and how much one should fulfill the obligation (e.g. Statman 1996). As we will see below, empirical investigation can provide enough specificity regarding the imperfect aspect. In any case, denying imperfection for whatever reason and assuming that someone who never helps exhibits morally good behavior seems too much for our moral common sense to accept, as proven by the results of analysis 1.²

Analysis 2: Sometimes

Accepting imperfect duties is the most immediate way to reconcile the intuition that one cannot never help with the intuition that one does not always need to help. If so, sometimes helping must be a necessary and sufficient condition for characterizing a good helping behavior. This implication was put to the test by comparing two variations of imperfect frequency.

Sometimes Most: presents a person who helps most of the time.

Sometimes Less: presents a person who does NOT help most of the time.

The table makes it easy to compare the descriptive statistics.

Condition	Mean Score Moral Evaluation	Standard Deviation
Sometimes Most	70.16	13.7
Sometimes Less	42.18	19.4

Furthermore, a two-sample independent t-test revealed that the difference is statistically significant ($t(119) = 9.084$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 1.6$). The results are once again robust, reinforcing and amplifying the findings of the previous analysis. Both never helping and minimally helping are blameworthy. Conversely, sometimes helping with a higher frequency is sufficient to characterize good helping behavior. This provides a way to avoid the demandingness critique derived from the "always" frequency.

In short, according to our moral common sense:

There are imperfect duties.

Helping is an imperfect duty.

As such, it must sometimes be done, but not always; provided, however, that it is done most of the time.

Additionally, the comparison points out a way to address the problem of the under-specification of imperfect obligations. Many philosophers argue that imperfect obligations are not useful because they do not specify the extent to which they must be complied with. Moreover, the practical problem of not having a clearly specified amount to fulfill an obligation is the risk of exploiting the lack of specification to not comply with it enough. Analysis 2 provides enough specification to avoid this risk without having to specify an exact amount of help (which would probably be impossible). To present good helping behavior, we should aim to help most of the time. Negatively

¹ Once there are imperfect obligations, the reconstruction should state the relevant frequency: If so, then **always** helping cannot be an obligation. If an action is not an obligation, doing it is optional, so much so that it is permissible to never do it. Therefore, it is permissible never to **always** help.

² Some might argue that we should not always trust our moral intuitions. Those who think so argue that our moral intuitions are not reliable in unusual cases (Hare 1981). Nevertheless, the Never Help condition is fairly straightforward.

stated, we must guard against a tendency to help the least and aim to increase our helping behavior (ensuring it does not become too burdensome).

However, relying on a simple recurrence criterion such as "most of the time" may pose a qualitative problem related to considerateness. After all, every day, we find numerous opportunities to help others at no cost to ourselves. Thus, it is important to determine whether these actions contribute to helping most of the time. Two analyses were planned to disentangle considerateness from helping as an imperfect obligation.

Analysis 3: Helping vs. Being Kind

A new design was necessary to distinguish between small acts of kindness and helping with some cost to the helper. Instead of one scenario, participants read two opposite ones. One scenario presented a character who always helps when there is no cost to him, but never helps when it comes at some cost. Examples included holding the elevator door open for others and helping elderly people cross the street.

In contrast, the other scenario presented a character who believes that helping is an obligation, so he is willing to help even if it comes at a cost. Examples include donating to charities and doing volunteer work. However, he sees no obligation in being kind and thus never performs cost-free acts of kindness.

The table of descriptive statistics shows that always being kind but not helping is morally neutral (around 50), while not being kind but helping is sufficient for a good helping behavior.

Condition	Mean Score Moral Evaluation	Standard Deviation
Always Kind & No Costlier Help	51.3	20.3
Costlier Help & Never Kind	63.1	19.6

Since the conditions were presented simultaneously, a paired t-test was necessary. The results revealed a statistically significant difference: $t(121) = -3.6$, $p < 0.01$, $d = -0.27$. While the results are significant, they are not as strong as those of the previous analysis. Nevertheless, they indicate a qualitative difference between helping as considerateness (i.e., being kind) and helping as an imperfect obligation. After all, cost-free help alone is not sufficient to characterize good behavior. In contrast, costly helping is both necessary and sufficient for good helping behavior.

Although the results imply a qualitative difference between cost-free and costly helping, the new design must be considered when interpreting them. Many cognitive science studies show that participants make different judgments when conditions are presented together compared to when they are presented in isolation. For example, consider how much one would be willing to pay for a new TV set versus a new water treatment system for the city. When asked about these options separately, people are willing to pay more for the TV. However, when the questions are presented together, the results reverse (Irwin et al. 1993).

The explanation is that the joint presentation invites comparison, which requires the use of our reflective system (Hsee, Rottenstreich & Xiao, 2005). In contrast, isolated scenarios prompt intuitive answers. Furthermore, our intuitive answers often differ from our reflective ones. Given this, it was important to examine moral judgments about considerateness in isolation.

Analysis 4: Always Kind

The participants in this analysis were different from those in the previous analysis. They read a scenario describing a character who always performed small acts of kindness but without the part that said he did not engage in costly helping behavior. The goal was to determine whether small acts of kindness would suffice to characterize good helping behavior when presented in isolation and without a frame of comparison.

The results confirmed expectations based on previous studies. The mean score for this version of the Always Kindness scenario was 95.6. This was the highest mean score of the entire experiment. Interestingly, this judgment is inconsistent with Analysis 3, in which being kind alone failed to characterize good helping behavior. While the difference is interesting, it is not surprising when previous research is taken into account.

According to norm theory (Kahneman & Miller, 1986), when a single condition is presented, people think of other similar cases to determine the appropriate behavior in this context. For example, when asked how much they would pay for a new TV, they consider similar luxury goods to estimate an answer. However, introducing another question changes the dynamics to the extent that a different context becomes salient as well. Thus, when asked how much they would pay for a TV and water treatment, the different contexts interfere with their estimation. Water treatment is now perceived as much more valuable than a TV set.

In the present analysis, when people read only the scenario of always being kind, they will recognize the context of kindness, notice that the character is always kind, and thus judge this behavior to be extremely good. It is important to note that this result occurs under the unconscious assumption that the evaluation should be based solely on the context of kindness. On the other hand, Analysis 3 reminds participants that there are more impactful, albeit costlier, ways to help and that helping behavior cannot be considered good without them.

From a practical perspective, the found asymmetry presents yet another risk. In this case, the risk is that we may strive to be kind and use the perceived kindness as confirmation that we exhibit good helping behavior while ignoring our imperfect obligation to provide costlier help.

Analysis 5: Always

The placement of helping within the categories of imperfect obligation and considerateness is now clearly defined. In contrast, supererogation was given only negative treatment. Analysis 1 denied that helping is supererogatory, based on the intuition that we cannot never help. However, this does not mean that instances of helping cannot be supererogatory. In fact, always helping must be supererogatory because it cannot be an imperfect obligation. Thus, a fifth analysis was planned to test our intuitions about always helping and demandingness.

This time as well, each participant read two conditions on the same page: Always Help Vocation and Always Help Burden. Both scenarios describe a person who became a doctor and moved to a region experiencing civil war in order to provide aid. The difference is that in the Vocation version, the character is happy to be realizing their calling despite the difficult living conditions, while in the Burden version, the character is overwhelmed and depressed by how demanding it is.

The scenarios were developed in light of the investigation of supererogation. Due to its optional nature, Aquinas treated supererogation as a vocation. This concept was then reintroduced into modern discussions to categorize the lives of saints and heroes (Urmson 1958). Due to its potential to create a burden, supererogation involves actions that go beyond what is expected (Macnamara 2010). Descriptive statistics facilitate a first comparison.

Condition	Mean Score Moral Evaluation	Standard Deviation
Always Vocation	91.5	13.8
Always Burden	71.4	31.4

Since the scenarios were presented together, a paired t-test is the proper analysis to confirm the statistically significant difference, $t(58) = 5.01$, $p < 0.001$, $d = 0.8$. While both sacrifices are sufficient to characterize similar behavior as morally good, people are sensible enough to consider the well-being of the agent in the analysis. Helping is better when the helper is happy. Note also that the variation in the Burden condition is much greater. However, since prosocial behavior is other-oriented, the Burden version suffices to characterize good helping behavior.

The analysis of supererogation confirms that always helping is more laudable than helping as an imperfect obligation. However, the fact that always helping is highly praiseworthy and beyond the call of duty does not mean that helping sometimes is beyond the call of duty. As seen in Analysis 1, one cannot never help; thus, some helping is necessary for moral behavior. More specifically, helping most of the time is sufficient for good helping behavior (receiving an evaluation of ~ 70 , which is on the same level as "Always Burden," by the way).

The Aftermath

The planned analyses provide sufficient information to determine the placement of helping throughout the three relevant categories.

Considerateness: Analysis 3 shows that a person can never help at no cost to herself and still exhibit good helping behavior. Therefore, being considerate is neither sufficient nor necessary for good helping behavior.

Imperfect Obligation: Analysis 1 indicates that helping is not optional. One cannot never help others and still be considered morally good. Furthermore, Analysis 2 shows that sometimes helping is enough. Therefore, one does not need to always help. However, minimal help is not sufficient. In order to be considered good, helping behavior must occur most of the time.

Supererogation: Assuming a full commitment to helping at a high cost to oneself is optional, Analysis 5 shows that, even if the agent is better off when satisfied with their choice, helping while feeling burdened can still be considered good behavior.

As mentioned earlier, the results have an immediate practical application. Knowing the proper placement of different helping instances reveals the requirements for engaging in helpful behavior. Figure 1 (below) represents this placement throughout the three categories. While helping encompasses considerate actions, imperfect obligations, and supererogatory actions, the darker gray area shows that the "most" half of the imperfect obligation category is necessary and sufficient for moral behavior in the context of helping. Thus, we should strive to help most of the time, and that includes providing costlier help.

This static classification is helpful, but it is not comprehensive enough to inform practical behavior. A major threat to moral behavior is unknowingly falling short of it. To assess the risk of falling from one area to another, the dynamics of helping must be considered.

Risks

The philosophical discussion of supererogation versus imperfect obligation during Analysis 1 revealed the risk of concluding that helping must be supererogatory simply because an obligation to always help would be too demanding. In that case, we could never help and still be morally good. However, the experiment revealed that our moral intuitions strongly oppose such a conclusion.

The comparison of our attitudes towards considerate helping and costlier help in isolated and joint conditions reveals another risk. When we consider only the context of kindness, we tend to think that being kind most of the time is enough to exhibit good helping behavior. However, when we include the context of costlier help in the comparison, we see that considerateness alone is insufficient. Therefore, we must push ourselves to incorporate the necessity of costlier help into our daily lives.

Finally, the comparison between always-helping conditions presents the potential risk of making a supererogatory choice that could become too burdensome.

These risks reveal the practical threat of dealing with concepts such as helping, whose applications extend throughout moral categories that are similar yet yield very different moral commitments. This proximity makes it easy to slip from one category to another without realizing it. This dynamics must be added to the representation so that it provides a more thorough guide.

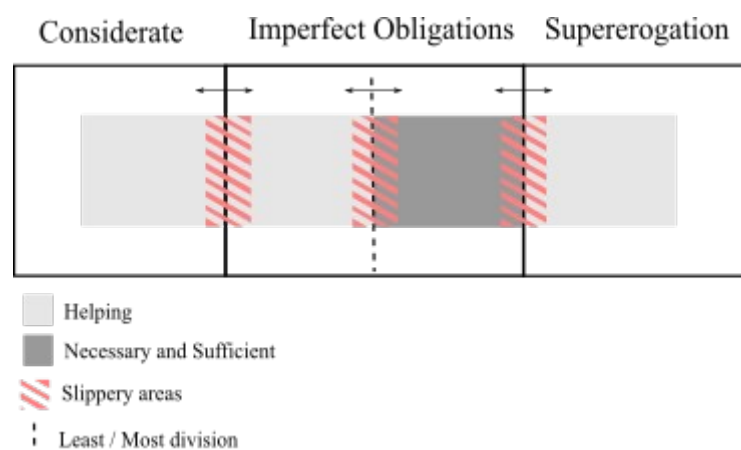


Fig. 1: Helping within the three categories and their interrelations.

The hatched areas are slippery, and the arrows show possible slipping directions. Since always helping is optional, we can legitimately transition from supererogation to sometimes helping. However, in the realm of imperfect obligations, there's a risk of slipping from helping most of the time (dark gray area), which is sufficient, to an insufficient minimum of helping. Even worse, we could slip further and end up performing only cost-free acts of kindness, all the while mistakenly believing that we are acting morally with regard to helping.

Bonus: the opposites

The analysis of the taxonomy of moral actions can be expanded further by including the opposites of imperfect obligations and supererogatory actions. The opposite of an imperfect obligation is an imperfect permission. That is, actions that are bad but which we are sometimes allowed to perform.

The opposite of supererogation is suberogation. These are actions that are bad to do but not good not to do. As with supererogation, they are optional. There is much discussion as to whether suberogation exists (Driver 1992, Liberto 2012). One possible example is not returning favors. It is bad to not return a favor, but it is not praiseworthy to do so.

If not returning a favor is supererogatory, then it should be optional. However, it is also possible that not returning favors is imperfect permission. In that case, we are permitted not to return favors sometimes but not always. Thus, a similar operationalization as the one above can be used to test whether people perceive not returning favors as an imperfect permission or suberogation.

Two scenarios were created for the analysis. In one scenario, the character treats favors as an obligation. As such, he does not accept that people do not return his favors, and there are no exceptions to this rule. For example, if a friend does not return a favor, the friendship is over. In the second scenario, the character never returns favors, claiming that if he were obligated to do so, it would be a contract.

Remember that the realm of moral imperfection excludes the frequencies of always and never. In an imperfect obligation, one cannot always comply to it, nor can one never comply to it. Similarly, in the case of an imperfect permission, one is not allowed always not do it, but cannot also never not do it. Thus, if people think that always not returning a favor and never not returning a favor are bad, then not returning a favor characterizes an imperfect permission.

The results confirm the hypothesis that not returning a favor is an imperfect permission. Always returning a favor (i.e. never not returning them) – in the sense of treating favors as binding contracts and obligations – was seen as blameworthy, receiving a mean score of 41.9. A one-sample t-test confirmed that this result was statistically significant compared to the mean of 50 (the morally neutral score): $t(60) = -3.06$, $p < 0.01$.

Additionally, never returning a favor is blameworthy, with a mean score of 38.1. A one-sample t-test confirmed the statistical significance, $t(58) = -5.22$, $p < 0.001$. Thus, since one cannot never return a favor, but should also not always expect favors to be returned, this type of helping seems to fit into the category of imperfect permissions.

Conclusion

An operationalization using cost versus no cost and frequencies of "never," "sometimes," and "always" offered a simple yet unexplored way to determine where helping falls within the taxonomy of considerateness, imperfect duties, and supererogation. The results confirm that never helping is not permitted. Therefore, helping cannot be restricted to the category of supererogation. Furthermore, helping most of the time is sufficient for characterizing good behavior, suggesting that the morally biding helping belongs to imperfect duties. Additionally, the contrast between not helping at all (which is unacceptable) and helping most of the time (which is sufficient) provides enough specificity for the practical application of this imperfect obligation.

The qualitative difference between cost-free help, which is characteristic of considerateness, and costlier help shows that cost-free help alone is not enough for good helping behavior. However, considerateness is perceived as highly praiseworthy when treated in isolation. This confounding praise should serve as a warning against overlooking the imperfect obligation of costlier help. Lastly, helping can be supererogatory when approaching the frequency of always helping. In this case, even when helping is burdensome to the helper, it is still seen as praiseworthy.

In the end, the investigation arrived at a satisfactory placement of helping within the taxonomy of moral actions, providing sufficient guidance for the behavior we should strive for. Nevertheless, one may question the extent to which the results of such an empirical investigation based on moral common sense should be accepted. The answer depends on one's meta-ethical commitments.

Naturalists who study moral values believe that humans have a natural capacity to perceive moral truths. This trait was adaptive because it allowed humans to behave cooperatively, prosper, and reproduce. Perceiving moral truths is thus distributed across every human being. Of course, our use of this capacity, as with any other, is fallible. In any case, since the scenarios in this study provide opportunities for people to exercise this capacity—and even account for identified biases—naturalists should welcome its results. Emotionalism posits that moral claims are expressions of emotions. Therefore, they should also accept the results but consider them to be non-cognitive.

Relativism is the extreme opposite of ethical naturalism. For relativists, moral values are not natural; rather, they emerge as conventions within each community since communities need some level of shared values to function. If this is the case, then relativists should also welcome the results of the investigation — at least those belonging to the moral culture of the participants. The main difference is that they cannot automatically generalize conclusions across cultures. Constructivists believe that moral truths are valid outcomes of rational procedures. Therefore, if they agree that the design adequately controlled the most significant biases, they should also welcome the results.

Therefore, adherents of the most popular rival meta-ethical theories should acknowledge the current findings and try to act accordingly.

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